

History of the Sunloch-Gabbro

In 1915 George Winkler of Victoria found chalcopyrite float on the beach near the mouth of the Jordan River. He succeeded in tracing the float up the river to its source on the east wall of the canyon. On July 30, 1915, Winkler and associates staked the claims later known as the Sunloch and on September 15, 1915, Winkler and associates staked the nucleus of the Gabbro group. Further claims were added to these groups in 1917 when J. M. Turnbull, R. H. Stewart, and Jack Hanna staked the Gabbro, Adaline and the War Eagle.

In 1917 Winkler bonded the Sunloch group to R. H. Stewart and Associates of Vancouver who organized the Sunloch Mining Company. R. H. Stewart was managing director and Jack Hanna was foreman. During 1917 a narrow gauge railway was built and diamond drilling and surface and underground work were done.

In 1919, The Consolidated Mining and Smelting Company acquired a majority interest in the Sunloch. W. M. Archibald, Chief Consulting Engineer for the Consolidated was appointed General Manager and Jack Hanna, Superintendent.

In 1920 further drilling, cross-cutting and drifting was done. The erection of a concentrating plant was postponed because of high costs and an unfavourable copper market. Jack Hanna resigned and George Kilbourne succeeded him. The property was left in charge of a caretaker.

The Gabbro Copper Mines Ltd. was organized in 1920

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with George Winkler as managing director to explore the Gabbro group. Surface prospecting and some underground work was carried out in the next few years.

The properties lay idle until 1949 when the Sunloch and Gabbro were optioned from their owners by Hedley Mascot Gold Mines. Hedley Mascot did extensive diamond drilling on the property during 1949 and 1950.

In 1956 the two properties were consolidated under the name Sunro Mines Limited.

In 1957 an adit was started to explore the downward extension of an extensive shear zone. This adit was driven a total of 7,805 feet.

In 1960 an operating lease was obtained from the Consolidated Mining and Smelting Company by Cowichan Copper Company Ltd.

In 1961 rehabilitation of the surface plant was commenced and underground mill installation was begun.

In 1962 the underground mill was completed and production started on May 1, 1962.

In 1963 production ceased because of flooding. The total production from May 1, 1962 to December, 1963 was 411,684 tons yielding 3,034 ounces of gold, 33,311 ounces of silver, and 13,123,221 pounds of copper.

In 1965 Sheep Creek Mines Limited agreed to provide management for Cowichan Copper.

Sheep Creek Mines, Ltd. changed its name to Aetna Investment Corporation Limited in 1965.